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PHOTOS BY JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

Unable to walk, talk, or eat, Rohan Shukla needs the constant help of his parents, Abhishek Shukla and Deepika Talukdar.

DAMAGE DONE, BUT WHY?

Family of catastrophically hurt football player still waiting on school district about probe



Talukdar showed a photo of Rohan when he played for Sharon High School.

By Bob Hohler

GLOBE STAFF

Rohan Shukla has a dream — a vision he can share only in writing, with his one functioning hand.

He wants to be lifting weights, running sprints, and catching passes, preparing with his teammates at Sharon High School for a new football season.

Instead, he lies at home in a hospital bed, his critically damaged brain unable to tell much of his body what to do. He can smile faintly, but he can't speak. He can smell his mother's cooking, but he can't eat or drink. He can move his right leg, but he can't walk. He is 16. He takes nourishment through a tube to his stomach and relies on his parents for his daily care.

In his largely immobile left hand, he grips a stuffed toy teddy bear — a gift from an ambulance crew that transported him as he lay near death after he suffered a catastrophic brain injury during Sharon's Thanksgiving football game last year.

His parents, meanwhile, attend to him around the clock while they and others wait for the Sharon school district to accept its share of responsibility for Rohan's devastating plight.

Three months have passed since the Globe first told the story of Rohan's struggle to come back from the brink of death. He returned home in late May, back where he can hear birds sing and can banter with his twin brother, Naman, while he en-

FOOTBALL, Page C6

COVID pushed many families to drop public schools for private

Wealthy communities show biggest shift

By Christopher Huffaker

GLOBE STAFF

Jessica Weed, a Newton nurse practitioner and mother of three, always thought her children would go to the city's highly regarded public schools.

She bought a house in Newton in the same neighborhood she grew up in, and sent her children to the same elementary school she attended, the Cabot. From 2020 to 2021, when her eldest was in first and second grades for remote learning, she kept him at the school, even as many neighbors left for in-person private education.

But as two of her three chil-

dren progressed through the schools, she became dissatisfied with both the rigor available to her son and the response to bullying faced by one of her daughters, prompting her to move the two to private school.

Financially, it will be a "big, huge burden," Weed said. "But it's worth it . . . for them to reach to their potential."

Before the COVID-19 pandemic, private schools across Massachusetts were losing students in droves. But in recent years, private school enrollment has remained nearly steady for the first time in de-

CADES. Families who left for private schools that were open in-person earlier than their local districts have stayed, while others like Weed's have switched since, in search of different academic or social experiences for their children. A smaller group of parents is also embracing home schooling at much higher rates than ever before.

If private schools had kept losing students at the same rate as they were pre-pandemic, they would be down some 10,000 additional children, according to a new study from Boston University researchers. Public schools, meanwhile, have lost students even more

SCHOOLS, Page A7

'The way I look at it, they kidnapped me from Canada and took me to the United States.'

EDOUARD LALLEMAND,
who fishes in Canada

As US hardens northern border, a question of crossing the line

By Paul Heintz

GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

BURLINGTON, Vt. — For most of his 60 years, Edouard Lallemand has fished the waters of northern Lake Champlain, reeling in bass near the border of the United States and his native Québec. During hockey playoff season, he casts a line between periods.

"My life is work, family, and fishing," said Lallemand, a welder who repairs trucks and tractors. "That's what I do. That's all I do."

So when a US Coast Guard vessel approached him on the lake last month and told him the boat he was piloting had entered American waters, the Canadian citizen was incredulous.

"It's impossible I was in America," he said.

By his own admission, Lallemand ignored the Coast Guard's commands and tried to high-tail it toward the Canadian shoreline. By the end of the encounter, his boat had capsized, he'd been pulled from the water, and he was handcuffed — bruised and bloodied — in a Vermont jail cell.

"The way I look at it, they kidnapped me from Canada and took me to the United States," he said.

The Coast Guard said it has investigated the incident and confirmed that both vessels were in the United States and that its crew members acted appropriately.

The encounter occurred as the United States continues to harden its vast northern border in

CANADA, Page A10

Filling a hole on the South Shore

Hardly Saints Donuts, run by Camden Moya and Anissa Davidson, is one of several new businesses gaining a following in the area. **G1.**



JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

Group aims to put rent control on the ballot

Tenants back a statewide cap; opposition from real estate industry will be stiff

By Andrew Brinker

GLOBE STAFF

Escalating a divisive battle between housing advocates and the powerful real estate industry, the tenant coalition Homes for All Massachusetts said it will launch a campaign Wednesday to put a measure to re-legalize rent control on the ballot in November 2026.

The move comes amid mounting frustrations over the cost of housing in Massachusetts that is driving low- and middle-income residents out of Greater Boston and the failure of the Legislature to take up rent control bills year after year. Homes For All's proposed question would create a statewide "rent stabilization" program that would tie annual increases for most apartments to inflation, with a hard annual cap at 5 percent, but also include some important exemptions.

If voters backed the measure, it would be one of the tightest rent control policies in the country, and unlike previous policies floated by advocates here, would cap rents statewide, as opposed to giving cities and towns the option to enact rent caps if they choose.

"We want the Legislature to do its job," said Carolyn Chou, executive director of the Homes For All coalition. "But they have failed to act for years, and the housing crisis continues to grow and disproportionately impact low-income families. This is us saying we can't keep waiting

RENT CONTROL, Page A10

With NIH grants trickling back in, scientists wonder where to start

By Sarah Rahal

GLOBE STAFF

In early February, Ethan Moitra was one of the first researchers at Brown University to learn that his federal funding had been canceled. He had enrolled 240 participants in a study examining how the pandemic affected rates of depression and anxiety, particularly among LGBTQ+ individuals. The grant was reinstated this month, but picking up where the research left off is proving complicated.

"It's great news, but a weird twist," Moitra said. "We've only got five weeks left. And during the pause, people moved on, staffing changed, the cohesion of the team is gone."

After a federal judge in Boston ordered the National Institutes of Health to reinstate 891 biomedical research grants in June, scientists had a brief moment of celebration after months of laying off staff, rescinding job offers, and agonizing over the future of their life's work.

In New England, 63 of those grants, worth \$126 million, are set to be restored, according to a Globe analysis based on the Grant Watch database. But researchers say the process of restoring their funding and restarting their projects remains clouded by confusion and delays.

The grants were restored as the result of a lawsuit filed by the American Public Health Association and 16 state attorneys general arguing that

GRANTS, Page A6

Talks between Harvard and the Trump administration are intensifying over a possible settlement, a Trump official said. **B1.**

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. delivered a blow to the country's capacity to develop vaccines, targeting messenger RNA shots. **B7.**

The red-hot Red Sox rolled to their seventh straight win, a 6-2 victory over the Royals, behind the usual strong start by Garrett Crochet. **C1.**

Smoked on the water

Wednesday: Still hazy, cool. High 72-77. Low 60-65.

Thursday: More of the same. High 74-79. Low 62-67.

Sunrise: 5:42 Sunset: 7:57

Weather and Comics, G6-7. Obituaries, C9.

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